

and 18 years old and were keen on introducing such modules to sensitise teachers but we are now being forced to suspend our plans." In Karnataka, the JDS-BJP Karnataka Development Front is saying no to the AEP. The minister for primary and secondary education, Basavaraj Horatti says "the sex education manuals were completely unfit for young children and could not be taught in the name of AIDS control. The drawings and the explicit content are against our values." Karnataka Chief Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy has insisted that though sex education may be necessary in the Western culture, it is not so in India, "which has a rich culture. My Government will not implement this manual as it will have an adverse effect on young children. Our values are good enough to impart whatever is necessary for these children and we don't have to opt for these western inspired education manuals."

This argument has been reiterated in Madhya Pradesh as well where chief minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan had to wind up the AEP for classes IX and X. Government sources say the chief minister's move was inspired by a strong pitch by Dinanath Batra, who is the chairman of the RSS off-spring Shiksha Bachao Samiti (SBA), which advocates against sex education in schools. The AEP was already running in 30 districts of the state and there were plans to cover another 18 so that all the 48 districts of the state were under its purview. A high-powered delegation of UNAIDS and UNICEF officials met some ministers and top bureaucrats but they



Cultural Context

There is a clear distinction in the material prepared by UNICEF for the 2005 AEP and the one prepared earlier by NCERT in 1999

- All images of men and women are clothed in the NCERT package of basic materials for the National Population Education Project.
- In the package, the focus of relationships with the opposite sex is appreciation and love, rather than sex.
- Erections, discussed in detail in the UNICEF module, don't figure in the NCERT package. Only masturbation does.
- Most activities in the NCERT package are individual, like self-tests, rather than focused on the group.

LESSONS TO LEARN: Aimed at teachers, not children

said they would be unable to rescue the AEP as the chief minister's mind "was already made up". In Gujarat, the opposition has been fuelled by a prominent Jain monk Udayvabhvijayji Maharaj. His pamphlet *Red Alert*, which paints a scary scenario of the future and says "sex education will lead the new generation to lose its virtues" has been circulated by SBA nationwide. It has been enough for the Gujarat Government to cite "strong public sentiments on the issue" and decide against sex education in schools.

The broader objective of adolescent education—which Pandey argues is an accurate term because it encompasses more than sex education—is what Rajendra Barve, psychiatrist-counsellor and president of the Bombay Psychiatric Society, calls the information gap. "In our society parents feel uncomfortable talking about sex. So it becomes the duty of schools and counsellors to make sure that kids get proper information. Else, they will acquire this knowledge from uninformed friends or the Internet. Sex

education should be about acquiring and effectively carrying out responsibilities of an adult and not just about sexuality."

This openness is echoed by the direct stakeholders—such as school teachers. "Our programme is about life skills and the physical and emotional changes that adolescents face. They can't just be swept away," explains Deepshikha Srivastava, principal of Mumbai's Rajhans Vidyalaya. Similarly, Usha Iyer, Principal of Pune's Kendriya Vidyalaya No. 2, says that her school has doctors and counsellors discussing various adolescent issues with students. "If sex education is handled sensitively and with decency, it should not be a problem. Besides, we do not distribute any literature which could be explicit," she says.

There are a number of lessons in this episode for all the participants. From the international agencies, perhaps a greater awareness of cultural complexities is demanded. For the HRD Ministry, it is to not let politics take over education again. As for NCERT, its slow and steady handling of AEP has been reconfirmed—it is now revising its own material within the stated objectives of providing accurate scientific learning, developing life skills among adolescents and responsible sexual behaviour in the age of instant gratification.

with Aditi Pai, Ambresh Mishra, Stephen David, Uday Mahurkar and M.G. Radhakrishnan



"SEX EDUCATION SHOULD BE ABOUT CARRYING OUT DUTIES OF AN ADULT, NOT JUST SEXUALITY."

RAJENDRA BARVE,
PSYCHIATRIST